

RemAining Relevant

How Economists Can Evolve Before AI Eats Their Lunch

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Economics and Generative AI

This is a big topic and could mean:

- How AI affects society and the economy
- Using AI to increase productivity, scope, and scale
- Using deep learning techniques in Economic models

I will focus on using AI tools to super-charge the workflow for Economics

The AI-Powered Economist

Economists risk obsolescence if we don't update our workflow to use Gen AI:

- Convergence of job families into a “Super IC”
- Increased impact and expanded frontier of possibilities
- Reduced dependencies on other specialists (e.g., engineers, IT, etc.)
- Must embrace short term pain to integrate AI into our workflow

Agenda

Today, I will demo a couple ways AI is changing how Economists work:

- Everyday tasks using [Kiro CLI](#)
 - ▶ Working with documents (summary, assessment, writing)
 - ▶ Eliminating toil (convert whiteboard images to markdown)
 - ▶ Assessing submissions for a poster session
- Performing research and automation using [Quick Suite](#)
- Building code to answer research questions using *prompt driven development* using [Kiro CLI](#) or [Kiro](#)

Helpful things to install for this demo

- Download and install [Kiro CLI](#).
- Verify Kiro will run a simple prompt
- Ensure you can access Git Hub: I will distribute materials this way
- Ensure you have either a working Python (such as `conda/mamba`) or R installation

Optional helpful things to install

Optional: On OS/X,

- Install [iTerm2](#), which will make using the Terminal/CLI much more pleasant.
- Install [Home Brew](#) (aka 'brew') which will provide Unix-ish commands

Optional: On Windows,

- Install Windows terminal + widget or equivalent (such as Chocolatey)
- Note: I do not use Windows so YMMV

Key Terms

- Large Language Model (LLM): a stateless, non-deterministic predictive algorithm—essentially a model architecture plus weights
- Tool: a service the LLM can call using Model Context Protocol (MCP) to complete a task such as reading a PDF
- Skill: another name for a tool
- Prompt: instructions you provide to perform some task
- Context: additional input to nudge the LLM to produce relevant results (a prior and constraints)

Agent Reasoning Loop

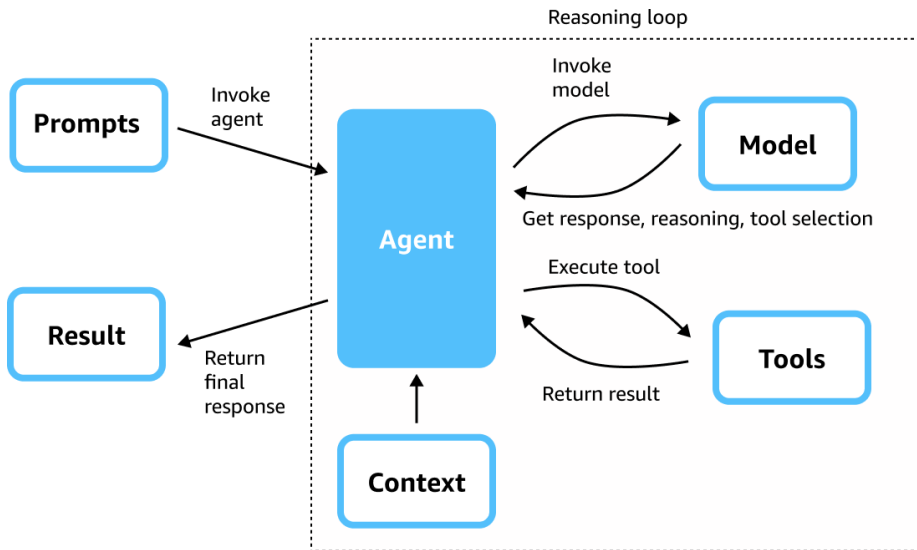


Figure 1: Agent Reasoning Loop

Warning: Ownership and Quality

You remain the owner of all work you create with Gen AI:

- Trust but verify
- Don't cowboy push some vibe coded AI slop to prod. . . .
- You are still responsible for quality and ethical standards of your work
- Don't outsource your thinking to AI, use it to accelerate your workflow
- Fact-check every fact at the original source